

S02-03 - Bramble Union Ambush

Player read-aloud

Bramblefolk burst from the undergrowth, blades drawn. Their eyes keep flicking toward the carriage. They are here for the cargo.

Scene summary

Bramble Union reclaimers attack the carriage to seize the cargo.

Visible choices

- Fight to kill
- Fight to subdue
- Protect the crate
- Negotiate under pressure

Player questions

- What detail in Bramble Union Ambush tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- What detail on a reclaimer's gear makes them look like a craftsperson from a hidden community rather than a disposable bandit?

Raw source

- Id: S02-03
- Act: Act Two
- Title: Bramble Union Ambush
- Beats: Combat Meaningful choice Corporate satire beat
- Image: assets/scenes/S02-03-bramble-union-ambush.png
- Short: Bramble Union reclaimers attack the carriage to seize the cargo.
- Long: The Bramble Union are the immediate antagonists, but they are desperate rather than cartoon evil. They are dangerous, armed, and under pressure.
- Read: Bramblefolk burst from the undergrowth, blades drawn. Their eyes keep flicking toward the carriage. They are here for the cargo.
- Gm: Offer ways to incapacitate, scare off, capture, or negotiate if players push for it.
- Entities: Bramble Union Ambusher Bramble Union Claimrunner Keystone Asset Bramble Union Bramble Union Villages Bramble Stone Tumblers Bramble Union Stoneweave The Wandering Briar Bramble Ward-Scrap Charm Cluster Claimrunner Serrated Blade Vial of Briarpowder Marlowe Fairwind Reclaimer Personal Effects Escort Carriage Kazrak Industries Hidden Sealed Keystone Crate The Grail Damage / Armor Hush Fear
- Choices: Fight to kill Fight to subdue Protect the crate Negotiate under pressure
- Prompt: Dynamic forest ambush: bramblefolk reclaimers spring from thorny brush to seize carriage cargo; armor patched with stones, shipping seals, torn contract tags;

adventurers defend carriage; no strixwolf, no undead.

- Source Entities: Bramble Union Ambusher Bramble Union Claimrunner Keystone Asset Bramble Union
- Beat Codes: combat meaningful-choice corporate-satire-beat
- Slug: S02-03-bramble-union-ambush
- Act Title: Cargo Reclaimers
- Arc Role: External opposition and morally complicated conflict
- Caption: The Bramble Union ambush should feel dangerous and understandable at the same time.
- Image Alt: Bramble Union Ambush scene art for Cargo Reclaimers.
- Image Prompt Used: Dynamic forest ambush: bramblefolk reclaimers spring from thorny brush to seize carriage cargo; armor patched with stones, shipping seals, torn contract tags; adventurers defend carriage; no strixwolf, no undead. Do not include the Strixwolf Mother, strixwolf pups, wolves, owlbeats, or animal companions unless explicitly requested. Do not include undead, skeletons, wraiths, Open Vale, the Custodian, or the Hanging Office. 4:3 cinematic fantasy concept art, no visible text, no captions, no logos, no UI, no watermark.
- Long Storyboard: The Bramble Union are the immediate antagonists, but they are desperate rather than cartoon evil. They are dangerous, armed, and under pressure. Run this scene as external opposition and morally complicated conflict: The Bramble Union ambush should feel dangerous and understandable at the same time. Keep the camera close to practical choices, visible consequences, and the difference between ordinary people and the infrastructure pressing on them.
- Read Aloud: Bramblefolk burst from the undergrowth, blades drawn. Their eyes keep flicking toward the carriage. They are here for the cargo.
- Gm Notes: Offer ways to incapacitate, scare off, capture, or negotiate if players push for it. Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it. The Bramble Union ambush now points back to hidden villages, stoneweave armor, and thorns used as shelter from surveillance. Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic. [REFLAVOR/GUARANTEED] The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. [REFLAVOR/GUARANTEED] Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. (Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue) [ADD/EARNED] "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying."
- Sensory Details: sweat under patched leather dirt kicked into carriage wheels a shout that sounds rehearsed because fear needed a script
- Body Language: The Claimrunner looks at the crate more than the party Ambushers hesitate when civilians are named
- Sample Dialogue: Claimrunner That box buys another month of their safety and another year of ours getting sold. Marlowe Fairwind You do not get to solve theft with a corpse in the road.
- Checks: Agility or Strength Hold the carriage line. Standard Prevent the Keystone from being seized. 15 Cleanly resolve: Hold the carriage line. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to Bramble Union Ambush. The full goal

slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence.

The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to close the ambush net, threaten the Keystone route, or force a choice between cargo and mercy. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth. Presence Force a pause for negotiation. Hard in combat Learn one displacement truth. 20 Cleanly resolve: Force a pause for negotiation. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to Bramble Union Ambush. The full goal slips...

- Choices Consequences: Kill The fight ends cleanly but the aftermath complicates victory. Personal effects sting. Capture or spare Reclaimers can reveal road claims and displacement. Bramble Resolution payoff. Negotiate Reduces bloodshed but keeps cargo risk alive. Corporate negligence surfaces early.
- Clues: Route sketch Someone leaked the route. Corporate logistics exposed Hush by treating risk as overhead. The Claimrunner knows the cargo route too well. Guaranteed seed The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. Guaranteed seed Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue Earned seed Available if players investigate, show mercy, or ask the right question. "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying."
- Loot: Use Bramble Union Ambushers and Claimrunner loot tables Bramble Union Stoneweave: A garment of thousands of tiny polished stones moves like cloth and turns thorns like armor. Every fitted piece looks cut by hands that loved the work. Vial of Briarpowder: A small stoppered vial holds fine grey-green thorn powder that seems to drink the light. A blade edge near it looks sharper and hungrier. Bramble Ward-Scrap Charm Cluster: A knot of blue ward shards, twine, and tiny salvage tags clacks softly at a Bramblefolk belt. It looks illegal only because it looks useful. Claimrunner Serrated Blade: A short serrated blade shows careful filing along the back edge and a handle wrapped in road cord. It is ugly in the practical way of a tool that has never had a decorative day.
- Payoff Flags: Bramble Union Resolution Track Strixwolf Mercy Track
- Filters: act-two-bramble-union-resolution-track cargo-reclaimers choice combat corporate-satire-beat gm-only meaningful-choice strixwolf-mercy-track faction manufactured-threat guaranteed-earned clue
- Index: 7
- Player Questions: What detail in Bramble Union Ambush tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real? What detail on a reclaimer's gear makes them look like a craftsman from a hidden community rather than a disposable bandit?
- Relationship Prompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownership Prompt: Name one detail in Bramble Union Ambush that belongs to your character's point of view.

- **Reveal Hooks:** Loreborne or Knowledge-focused PCs can read the institutional layer. Wildborne/community-focused PCs can read local custom and ecological stress. Martial/security-focused PCs can read threat posture and custody logic. Magic-focused PCs can feel ward tone, soul-signal, or spell instability. Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.
- **Fear Spends:** Spend Fear to close the ambush net, threaten the Keystone route, or force a choice between cargo and mercy. Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclaimer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- **Story Scope:** Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED A spared/captured reclaimer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. ADD EARNED Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture The reclaimers target the cargo and manifest, not purses, and avoid killing when possible. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Their gear includes salvaged, repainted Grail/Kazrak kit: ex-workers, not feral bandits. REFLAVOR GUARANTEED Knowledge Medium 15 to name the issue "That stone belongs in the ground." "You do not know what you are carrying." ADD EARNED Instinct: spot ambush. Presence: parley/interrogate...
- **Mechanics:** The party is in Act Two pressure: Bramble Union reclaimers attack the carriage to seize the cargo. Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting. s02-03-talk-down-the-claimrunner S02-03 Talk down the claimrunner Talk down the claimrunner Presence Knowledge Presence Knowledge 15 Presence meets fear; Knowledge names the road claim. Violence becomes the only language if nobody offers another one. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. Violence becomes the only language if nobody offers...
- **Roll Cards:** s02-03-talk-down-the-claimrunner S02-03 Talk down the claimrunner Talk down the claimrunner Presence Knowledge Presence Knowledge 15 Presence meets fear;

Knowledge names the road claim. Violence becomes the only language if nobody offers another one. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. Violence becomes the only language if nobody offers another one. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result, but it...

- Conditions Hazards: Restrained Hidden
- Search Loot Clues: Bramble ambushers: route map, ward-stone scraps, Firstmoss, personal keepsakes; do not make bodies treasure chests.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: Bramble Union Ambush asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Agility, Finesse, Instinct, Knowledge, Presence, Strength. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Factionids: bramble-union
- World Connection Prompts: S02-03-bramble-union-world-connection bramble-union The Bramble Union You have been desperate enough to do something you are not proud of. What was it, and would you do it again to eat?
- Location Ids: bramble-union-villages the-wandering-briar
- Item Ids: bramble-union-stoneweave vial-of-briarpowder bramble-ward-scrap-charm-cluster claimrunner-serrated-blade
- Clueids: reclaimer-personal-effects the-held-blow the-interrogation-answer
- Clue Ids: reclaimer-personal-effects the-held-blow the-interrogation-answer
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